stopped just inside the territorial limit, and the two navies settled for the moment into a watchful stalemate.

The next three days slowed to a dead calm in the region as the various task forces and ships of both sides neared each other. Neither Newsom nor Xi was willing to declare war on the other country, with all the implications that held, but Xi declared a national emergency, and Newsom briefed congressional leaders, who quickly passed a nonbinding resolution declaring support for US forces in Asia and for President Newsom's policy of maintaining a "peaceful and prosperous Indo-Pacific." Despite repeated phone calls between the leaders, neither agreed to pull back forces. Instead, Newsom approved the dispatch to Japan of ten more DDGs and two cruisers from San Diego, though their transit would take at least two weeks. Another two squadrons of F-22s were ordered to Kadena, and two B-2 bombers from Whiteman Air Force Base made a transoceanic flyby over the Senkakus. When Newsom asked for permission to base the F-22s at Clark, widespread anti-US protests broke out in the Philippines, including massive demonstrations that besieged the base; these were organized and directed by Chinese intelligence agents, but they served to paralyze Philippine politics, especially once former president Duterte emerged at the head of the protestors demanding that Manila restore peaceful relations with Beijing.

On September 15, the PLAN South Sea Fleet task force reached the position of the *Curtis Wilbur*, off the Spratlys. The *Bertholf* remained largely inoperable, and the DDG kept watch over the coast guard vessel. Despite warnings to keep a safe maritime distance, the Chinese ships closed in, forcing the DDG to fire warning shots, which were ignored. Being entirely outgunned, the commander of the *Curtis Wilbur* chose to batten down the ship and refrain from further hostilities, hoping to ride out any Chinese attack until relief forces could arrive; the Chinese, who had orders only to isolate the two American ships, formed a barrier around them. In the skies, US tankers had been withdrawn from their refueling stations, as Pacific Air Forces feared losing its limited number of them due to PLA fighters, while the